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ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

A HIGH TIDE floods the road, businesses and homes Tuesday along Pacific Coast Highway in Sunset Beach.

SoCal's coast is losing to El Niño flooding

Why the rising water that swamped several towns this week is likely to get worse.

BY HANNAH FRY AND RONG-GONG LIN II

Diane Copley-Botica stacked rows of sandbags and tarps around her home in Sunset Beach, hoping it might be enough to keep the rising water at bay.

But the seawater from record high tides came anyway, flowing across the neighborhood like a river, flooding homes and businesses along the stretch of Pacific Coast Highway.

Each day this week, neighbors tried a new strategy to buttress their homes from the rising tide. But it's never enough.

"All you can do is sit and wait and watch the water," she said. "No one has been able to figure out how to stop it."

The flooding this week has hit several Orange County coastal towns, but experts say it is likely just a preview of more intense problems to come this winter as a major El Niño is expected to bring heavy rain, high surf and flooding.

Cities have developed an arsenal of weapons against the tides: sandbags, water pumps, sand berms and drainage canals. Although the tools have shown some success, they have not be able to stop high tides from causing flooding. Pumps are pushing floodwater back into local bays, but it's a slow process that works only when high tides start receding.

"They're pumping it right back to where it's coming from," Copley-Botica said. "I mean where do you even put it? Nothing is working."

During the peak of El Niño, maximum water heights during king tides could be 1 to 2 feet higher than this week, scientists warn. And if big rainstorms emerge during those events, the coastal flooding risk could be catastrophic.

"If you imagine the amount of water that we saw this week, and then you add a foot to that ... plus a low-pressure weather system, that's going to be devastating for a lot of people who have never seen that much water," said Kristina Hill, a professor of landscape architecture, environmental planning and urban design at UC Berkeley.

Scientists say this marine heat wave has caused seawater levels to rise 1.25 to 1.8 feet higher than they would be just from the movement of the moon, Earth and

[See **Flooding,** A14]

When election denialism is on ballot

Citizens groups are volunteering to guard against possible federal interference nationwide

BY JUSTINE MCDANIEL

CHANDLER, Ariz. — At balloon-adorned tables in red, white and blue, a handful of voters inside a church gymnasium listened as Medina Moore explained what to do if federal agents show up at the polls.

Call a hotline, she told volunteers, where attorneys will be ready to respond. Take videos, report what you see and remove yourself from any situation that becomes intense, she advised.

It was one of Moore's final poll monitor trainings in the Phoenix area before election day, preparing a few new "peacekeepers" to join the ranks of about 200 she has recruited from local faith groups in the Phoenix area to greet voters, answer questions and keep an eye out for problems at voting sites on Tuesday.

"It feels very urgent this year," said Moore, the voting rights organizer for the Arizona Faith Network, a coalition of religious groups. "We're in an era of information overload. Being able to educate voters on what's true and what's not is very important."

As lawyers nationwide prepare defenses against possible election interference by the Trump administration and election officials train for worst-case scenarios, ordinary citizens across the country are also readying to help. Through nonpartisan groups, parents are training to be poll monitors, law students are staffing legal hotlines, veterans are holding voting events and business owners are signing pledges to back local election officials.

The grassroots efforts, underpinned by various voting and democracy nonprofits, amount to a striking push by American voters to help uphold the nation's election system in the face of possible threats from its own government. More than 21,000 people nationwide have been trained as

[See **Election,** A6]

PATRICK STEWART, 1940 - 2026

All the universe was his stage

Shakespearean actor is best known for sci-fi roles

BY TRACY BROWN

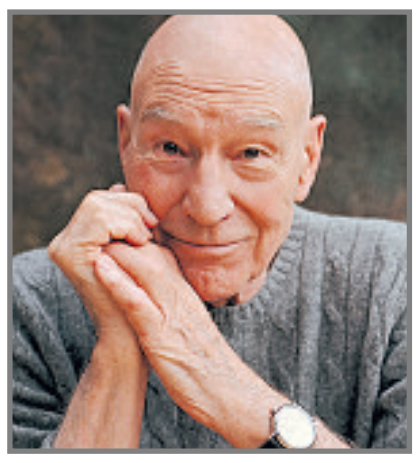
Patrick Stewart, the British actor whose 60-year career spanned the stage to the final frontier, has died. He was 86.

Stewart died Wednesday at his home in Los Angeles from Alzheimer's disease and Lewy body dementia, his longtime spokesperson, Kelly Bush Novak, said in a statement.

A classically trained stage actor, Stewart was relatively unknown to American audiences when he was cast to lead a revival of "Star Trek." In addition to portraying Jean-Luc Picard in "Star Trek: The Next Generation" and numerous follow-ups, he is known for playing Professor Charles Xavier in the "X-Men" franchise and voicing Avery Bullock in the animated "American Dad!"

"He has been held in the warm em-

[See **Stewart,** A14]



ERIK CARTER For The Times

BELOVED STAR
Patrick Stewart, shown at home in L.A. in 2023, was a classically trained stage actor from the U.K.



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

MINUS JAMES, LAKERS SOAR

Without LeBron James, Quentin Grimes (5) and the Lakers are now thriving with a 4-1 start to the season, Bill Plaschke writes. **SPORTS, B10**

High-speed rail CEO steps down

Interim chief is named after project faced cost overruns, delays and wasteful spending. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Virgin Galactic unveils new ship

Tustin-based pioneer of space tourism hopes to reignite business with six-passenger Delta class. **BUSINESS, A10**

Weather
A stray shower.
L.A. Basin: 72/61. **B6**

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Trump's DOJ intensifies its war over voting

California's attorneys gear up for battle after L.A. County officials receive subpoenas.

BY KEVIN RECTOR AND BRITTNY MEJIA

Soon after a federal judge in Los Angeles sharply rejected a Trump administration effort to block 20,000 California ballots from voters it alleged may be noncitizens, the U.S. Justice Department appealed — leaving attorneys on both sides preparing Thursday for yet another court battle.

That was despite the lower-court judge calling the request an unlawful threat to eligible voters in Tuesday's midterm election and to free and fair American elections moving forward, and the same appellate court having already rejected the plan days before.

"Every day, more ballots are processed by election officials. This ongoing emergency disenfranchises American citizens through dilution," wrote First Assistant U.S. Atty. Bill Essayli, the lead prosecutor in L.A.

Early Thursday, Gov. Gavin Newsom swiped back at the Trump administration, writing, "A warning to Donald Trump: I'm deploying election lawyers to key battleground districts in California to protect every vote. And I just made it a FELONY to illegally seize ballots."

With just days to go until polls close, the heated election war between California and the Trump administration is showing no signs of slowing down despite multiple court orders rejecting the administration's central effort to interfere in the midterms by accusing state and county officials of willfully turning a blind eye to voter fraud.

That's in part because lawyers within the U.S. Justice Department have been unrelenting in their pursuit of such control, both through court orders and threats to state and county officials — including through criminal grand jury subpoenas issued to at least three officials in Los Angeles County Registrar-Recorder/County Clerk Dean Logan's office.

The subpoenas, reviewed

[See **Fight,** A6]

Becerra widens his strong lead in poll

Voters are mixed about significance of first elected Latino governor if he wins.

BY NICOLE NIXON

SACRAMENTO — Xavier Becerra is poised to make history as California's first elected Latino governor, according to a new poll.

But the survey shows voters, and Latinos in particular, have mixed views on the significance and impact of Becerra's probable win.

According to the poll by the UC Berkeley Institute of Governmental Studies and co-sponsored by the Los Angeles Times, the veteran Democratic politician was backed by 61% of likely California voters, compared with 34% who supported his Republican rival, former Fox News commentator Steve Hilton. That is slightly up from a September IGS survey that showed Becerra leading by 25 percentage points.

"He's solidified almost unanimous support now among Democrats," IGS Poll Director Mark DiCamillo said. "Republicans are almost unanimous in the other direction."

Becerra, a former U.S. Health and Human Services secretary, congressman and state attorney general, "hasn't offended any significant parts of the Democratic Party" and has united the party's voters by "hammering away" against President Trump, DiCamillo said.

When asked to name one or two top priorities for the election, 40% of likely voters chose pushing back against the Trump administration, followed by 34% who cited reducing the cost of living. It's a reversal from the mid-September survey, when 44% of likely voters said the cost of living was a top issue and 37% listed fighting Trump.

Both of those issues far outweighed the concerns of California voters about other issues that dominated the political discourse in

[See **Governor,** A8]

Federal judge bars racial profiling by ICE agents

She cites a 'mountain of evidence' of bias from text messages, body-cam footage.

BY BRITTNY MEJIA

A federal judge barred immigration agents in Southern California from stopping people based on racial stereotypes, finding evidence of an unwritten, "officially sanctioned" policy of targeting people who appear Latino.

In her order granting a preliminary injunction, U.S. District Judge Maame Ewusi-Mensah Frimpong cited "a mountain of evidence" provided by the plaintiffs, including body-camera footage and text messages that captured immigration agents referring to Latinos using slurs such as "tonk" and "wet."

"The Government's showing that it trains agents to follow the law cannot defeat the mountain of evidence that, in practice, agents do not follow the law," Frimpong wrote.

The injunction, issued last week and unsealed Thursday, requires agents to establish individualized reasonable suspicion before detaining someone for immigration enforcement, rather than relying on racial stereotypes. Simply appearing to be Latino and working-class is insufficient, Frimpong wrote, even if a person shares those characteristics with an identified target. The order exempts stops at ports of entry, checkpoints and other functional equivalents of the border.

Frimpong noted that her ruling was not a final determination that the government maintained an unlawful policy. The Trump administration filed a notice of appeal Wednesday, seeking review by the 9th Circuit Court of Appeals.

The Department of Homeland Security, which

[See **ICE,** A8]